

Budgeting apps punish you on the weeks you need them *most.*

A UX and visual design case study for a money app
built on steadiness, not restriction.



Payday
+3 days
+1 week
+2 weeks

72%

of U.S. adults felt stressed about money at least some of the time in the past month.

So the person opening a finance app is already a little anxious. That's the default user, not the edge case.

When the news is bad, we look *away*.

Researchers call it the ostrich effect: investors checked their portfolios more often in rising markets than in falling ones.

An app that greets a rough week with red numbers is teaching people to stop opening it.

Not ~~What did you spend?~~

But **How long are you covered?**

You're steady through

Oct 25

9 days past your next payday. Bills before then are already set aside.

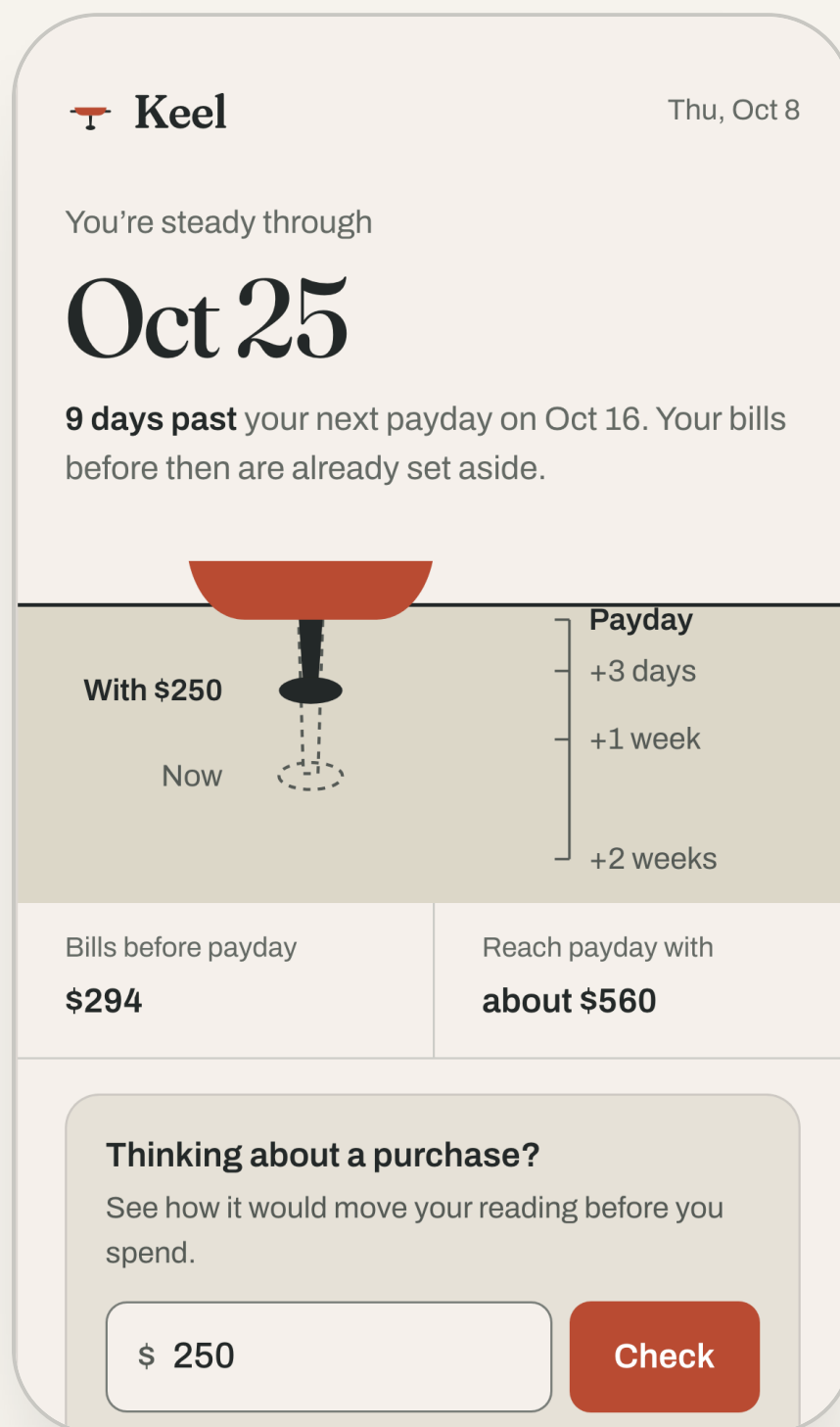
The headline is a date, not a balance: walk forward from today, subtract usual spending and bills, ignore future income.

One picture, one *meaning*.

The waterline is payday.
Always, on every screen.

The keel's depth is room.
How many days past payday
your money lasts.

Check before you buy.
A \$250 purchase shortens the
keel to 4 days; the dashed
outline shows where it was.



Weight, not *walls.*

Spending doesn't break limits. It shifts weight.

No red overages.

No category ceilings that “break”.

Cost in days, not guilt.

\$16.80 of sushi is about a third of a day of usual spending, already counted.

Hana Sushi

Wed, Oct 7 · \$16.80

\$16.80 is about a third of a day of your usual spending. It's already counted in your reading.

Category

Groceries

Eating out

Getting around

Health

Everything else

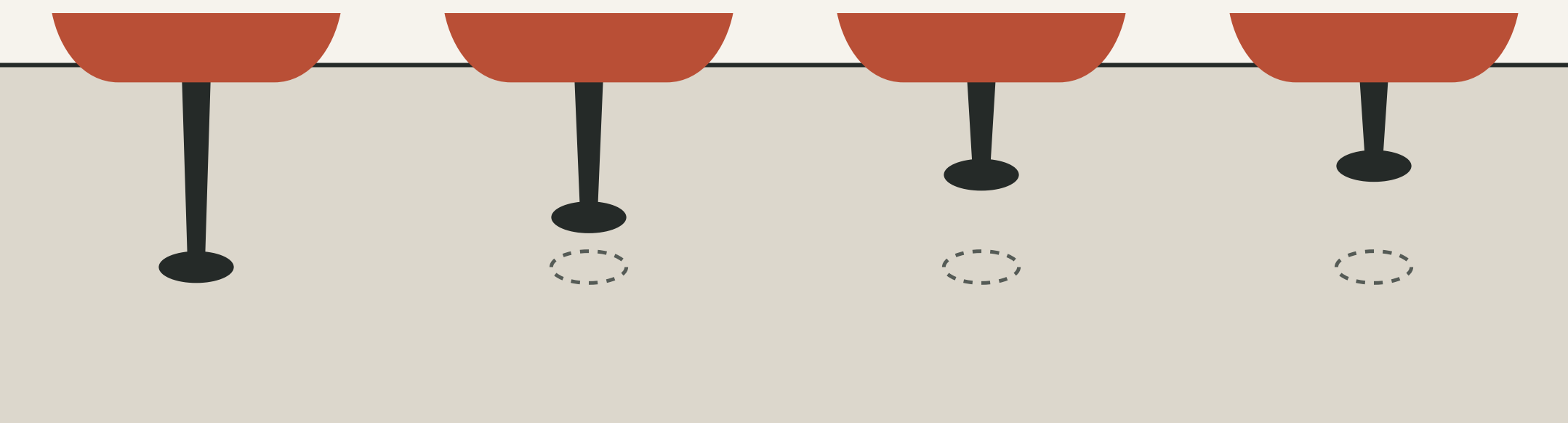
Travel

Save category

Cancel

Settle, don't *startle*.

When your reading changes, the keel eases to its new depth like a boat taking on weight, then stops. About 900ms, no bounce.



0ms

180ms

420ms

900ms

~~shakes~~~~red flashes~~~~confetti~~~~badge counts~~

12 Lottie animations and 4 Rive state machines, all written in code, each with a dark version and a reduced-motion state.

Calm still has to be *checked*.

0

contrast failures across 713 text measurements in 16 app states, light and dark

61fps

through the hero animation with the CPU slowed 4x

320px

narrowest screen tested with no sideways scrolling; keyboard focus stays inside every dialog

Not tested with people yet. The research is a literature and competitor review, and the five-second and task tests are planned, not run. The case study says so.

Read the case study. Then try the *prototype*.

Research, IA, wireframes, identity, motion system and a working app with real calculations. **Links in the comments.**

Should a money app ever show you red?